The injunction not to speak ill of the dead doesn't really apply to journalists. As Peres lay in the hospital, I found myself musing on what sort of an obituary to write. There was much to criticize, from his role in birthing the settler movement to his political cowardice as president—the substantive failings that were masked by the carefully-crafted image of Peres the indefatigable peacemaker. The bold-faced names at his funeral included some of Israel's wealthiest and most corrupt tycoons, a reminder of one of the seamier sides of his career. Yet there was also something admirable about a politician who reflected deeply on his positions, and genuinely changed them. "The politician you should really suspect is the one who doesn't change his mind over half a century," he once told me. It was the sort of political aphorism for which he was famous. It was also true.

Arguably the most notable guest at his funeral was not Obama or Prince Charles. It was Mahmoud Abbas, the Palestinian president. The leaders of Israel's own Palestinian party, the Joint List, did not attend, a decision for which they were rightly castigated in the local press. But Abbas made the trip from Ramallah, a decision that drew harsh criticism from rivals like Hamas. Even his own Fatah party expressed its displeasure in a Facebook post. At one point during the service, Abbas seemed to tear up; the photo was mockingly circulated on Palestinian social media.

He had a brief photo op with Netanyahu and his wife. The two leaders briefly shook hands and exchanged a few words. "Long time, long time," Abbas said in English, as if they were two old men bumping into each other on the crosstown bus. When it was time to speak, none of the Israeli politicians mentioned his presence, though Netanyahu found time to thank the Grand Duke of Luxembourg. It fell to President Obama to acknowledge him, telling the crowd that his "presence here is a gesture and a reminder of the unfinished business of peace." The prime minister also made no mention of his own party's history of scurrilous attacks on Peres. It was Rivlin, decent as ever, who broached the subject. "We will ask forgiveness", he said. "There were years in which red lines were crossed, between ideological disputes and words and deeds which had no place."

Netanyahu's speech, with a few revisions, could have been delivered on the campaign trail; it was a reminder of his differences with Peres, coated with a layer of schmaltz. "In one of our nearly night-long discussions, we addressed a fundamental question: From Israel's perspective, what is paramount: security or peace?" he recalled. "Shimon enthusiastically